

פרשת במדבר starts off with the story of כלל ישראל over their 40-year sojourn. Right at the very beginning עבודה tells משה רבינו that he has to choose people from each שבט to accompany him in his עבודה, whether it was the census or in doing that which was required to lead כלל ישראל. The pasuk says (1:4) וְאַתֶּם יְהִיוּ אִישׁ אִישׁ לְמִטָּה, which would be a fine way to conclude. But the pasuk continues: אִישׁ רֹאשׁ לְבֵית. The קשיא is: who is this person who is considered the head of the family? Is it the בכור? Is it someone with יחס? Is it someone more accomplished in learning? If יחס is, in fact, an important factor, there's a fascinating שאלה about יחס specifically. The sefer The Short Vort brings the following point:

Everybody is born into circumstances that can shape and support the development of their unique relationship with ה'קודש ברוך הוא. One who is not born with any particular יחס has to build that relationship from scratch. And even someone who does have יחס must still work on that relationship himself.

The קשיא is this: when יצחק and רבקה were davening to Hashem, רש"י tells us that Hashem listened to יצחק first. Why? Because the תפילות of a צדיק בן צדיק are given precedence over those of a רשע בן רשע. That's very שווער to understand. One would think the opposite - that someone like רבקה, who pulled herself out of an environment and upbringing steeped in רשעות, and made herself into a צדקה, should be on an even higher מדרגה. In fact, we know the famous gemara (ברכות ל"ד ע"ב) שְׂבַע עֶלְי תְּשׁוּבָה עוֹמְדִין צְדִיקִים גְּמוּרִים אֵינָם (ברכות ל"ד ע"ב) - a place where a בעל תשובה can get to, even a complete צדיק is unable to stand there. Why were יצחק's תפילות accepted prior to those of רבקה?

The answer is that Hashem preferred יצחק's תפילות not simply because he was a צדיק בן צדיק, but because he didn't merely copy his father's דרך in עבודת השם. That would have been easy. Instead, he forged his own דרך. We know that each of the אבות had his own unique method, his own form of עבודה, in his relationship with ה'קודש ברוך הוא. That is why each one is referred to as an עבודה, because each individually crafted a unique path in serving Hashem.

That is a lesson for all of us. Each of us, whether we have יחס or not, has the opportunity, the responsibility, and the challenge to forge a path in עבודת השם that is unique to himself. Every Yid is a star of his own. Each Yid has his own דרך in עבודת השם. That's what the pasuk is teaching us: get to work on your own דרך. Develop it. Build it. Serve Hashem in your own way, based on the מסורה of your forebears, but do the work yourself. If you do it yourself, you can succeed.

The sefer brings a story, the famous joke about the not-so-religious fellow who came over to the rabbi of the shul and said, "I'd like to duchan." The rav replies, "Duchaning is only for כהנים." The man responds, "No, no, I want to duchan. I'll give \$1,000 to the shul." "No." "I'll give \$5,000 to the shul." "No." "I'll give \$100,000 to the shul." Still, the rabbi says no. Finally, the rabbi asks him, "Why are you so interested in duchaning? You barely show up to shul, you never come to davening, and when you do, you're not particularly involved." The man replies, "Well, my father duchaned, and his father duchaned, and my grandfather duchaned. So I'd like to duchan too."

The point is clear: we all have to find our own way to serve Hashem. Perhaps the title of רֹאשׁ לְבֵית אָבִתָּיו would be conferred on the person most successful in developing his own עבודת השם.

